

**Speech of the Hon'ble Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu
Thiru. C. Joseph Vijay in the Eleventh Governing Council
Meeting of NITI Aayog**

Hon'ble Prime Minister,

Hon'ble Union Ministers,

Vice-Chairman and Members of NITI Aayog,

Hon'ble Chief Ministers and Lieutenant Governors,

Senior Officials !

Vanakkam to all !

I sincerely thank the Hon'ble Prime Minister for convening the 11th Governing Council Meeting of NITI Aayog. Tamil Nadu wholeheartedly supports the nation's aspirations and firmly believes that a developed India can be built only through empowered States, cooperative federalism, and inclusive development. The people of Tamil Nadu have entrusted our Government with a historic mandate founded on transparent governance, social justice, inclusive growth, youth empowerment and equitable development, and we remain committed to working constructively with the Union Government while firmly safeguarding the interests and aspirations of Tamil Nadu.

Despite global uncertainties, Tamil Nadu, India's second-largest economy, continues to demonstrate resilience and sustained growth. The State is working to become a 1.5 trillion dollar economy by 2036, reflecting the strength of our diversified economy and the productivity of our workforce, and underscoring our commitment to a Developed India by 2047. This vision is anchored on four pillars, Youth, the Poor, Women and Farmers and Tamil Nadu's priorities are closely aligned with each of them. I wish to place before this august Council a few key

priorities central to both our development and India's journey to becoming a developed nation.

Empowering India's Youth

India's greatest strength is its young population, and Tamil Nadu will continue to invest in education, skills, innovation, and employment to harness this demographic dividend. With this focus, I envisage a Youth Skill and Employment Mission under which five lakh youth annually will receive stipend-supported internships and industry-linked training, and we request the Union Government's support to establish emerging technology skill centres in every district and to train five lakh youth in Artificial Intelligence, Deep Technology, Cybersecurity, Cloud Computing, EV Technology, and Semiconductor-related sectors.

Committed to leveraging Artificial Intelligence for citizen-centric services and efficient governance, we seek the Government of India's support in creating world-class start-up incubators, a venture capital ecosystem for deep-tech enterprises, and enhanced funding for applied research.

Equally, the Government of Tamil Nadu is committed to protecting the rights of our students. The State is opposed to the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) for admission to undergraduate medical and dental courses, as its introduction has affected the students from rural and socio-economically disadvantaged families. In view of the above, the Government of Tamil Nadu may be permitted to fill all seats under the State quota in MBBS, BDS, and AYUSH courses based solely on Class XII marks.

Inclusive Growth and Poverty Reduction

Tamil Nadu firmly believes that economic growth must translate into an improved quality of life for every citizen. To this end, our Government proposes a comprehensive Poverty-Free Tamil Nadu Mission to identify vulnerable families and ensure the convergence of all welfare schemes for sustainable livelihood opportunities, and I seek the Union Government's financial assistance to realize the dream of affordable house for all.

To further strengthen tertiary healthcare, world-class medical education and bring quality care closer to our people, I also request that a second AIIMS for Tamil Nadu be sanctioned for Coimbatore, for which the State Government will provide the required land.

Women-Led Development

Women remain at the centre of Tamil Nadu's development journey, and their empowerment is not merely a social objective but an economic necessity. The State has made notable progress in women's education, health, safety, and economic empowerment. Women's Self-Help Groups have become powerful instruments of community development and socio-economic transformation. Tamil Nadu employs 42% of women working in factories in India and further to strengthen women's safety, we propose specialised women safety units, emergency response systems in public transport, expanded CCTV networks, and integrated command centres, and have launched the "Singa Pen Sirappu Athiradi Padai" (Women's Special Action Force) for technology-enabled policing and rapid response.

Strengthening Farmers and Rural Prosperity

Agriculture remains central to Tamil Nadu's economy and to the livelihoods of millions. Recognising the difficulties faced by farmers, the Government recently announced a targeted Cooperative Crop Loan Waiver Scheme of Rs.2,045 crore, benefiting marginal, small, and other farmers through structured debt relief.

The livelihoods and safety of our coastal fishing communities are an equal priority. I urge the Government of India to ensure the protection of the traditional fishing rights of Indian fishermen in the Palk Bay, and to guarantee their safety, security, and the release of their fishing boats. I further request urgent diplomatic measures to secure the release of Tamil Nadu fishermen apprehended and jailed in Sri Lanka and Pakistan, and to ensure their safe return to their families.

Given that our 1,076 km coastline is repeatedly affected by cyclones and flooding, Tamil Nadu seeks enhanced support for permanent flood mitigation infrastructure in coastal cities and a Comprehensive Disaster Management Mission aimed at zero causality alongside climate-resilient infrastructure under a Climate Resilient Master Plan 2045. We also look forward to the Government of India declaring the Space Manufacturing Hub at Kulasekarapattinam, set up with IN-SPACe, as a National Space Manufacturing Hub, enabling end-to-end manufacturing from propellants to launch vehicles and helping the nation tap into the global space economy.

Tamil Nadu's rapid economic growth also requires the timely development of key national highway and rail corridors, and I request the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways and Ministry of Railways to accord sanction to the following projects:-

- Six lane Chengalpattu to Trichy section of GST Road (NH-32).
- Six lane Trichy (Panchapur) – Jeeyapuram – Karur section (NH-81).
- Six lane Karur – Coimbatore section (NH-81).
- Elevated Corridor from Madhavaram to Shozhavaram (NH-87).
- High Speed Rail Corridor from Chennai to Kanniyakumari.

On digital connectivity, the BharatNet Phase-II project in Tamil Nadu has reached around 97% completion, and I seek the Government of India's support to resolve the remaining last-mile challenges and sustain network operations so that every Gram Panchayat is connected.

I further request the Government of India to provide the committed Central Assistance of Rs.2,283.40 crore for the Hogenakkal Phase-III Combined Water Supply Scheme.

States that have demonstrated fiscal responsibility, social progress, and population stabilisation should be recognised and adequately supported, and must not be disadvantaged.

I take this opportunity to request the Government of India to permit employment generation under VB-G RAM-G for the State Government Rural Housing Schemes as well.

I also request Government of India to release the pending Samagra Shiksha Scheme funds amounting to Rs.3,284 crore early without conditionalities and without linking the same to the implementation of New Education Policy or without insisting on the three language Policy, in the larger interest of student's welfare, continuity of educational services, and the preservation of cooperative federalism.

I would also like to place before this Council a request to the Government of India to declare Thirukkural, the ancient treatise that is uniquely relevant to the secular values of modern India, as a National Literature.

Tamil Nadu firmly believes that when States are empowered, India becomes stronger. Together, through partnership, mutual respect, and shared responsibility, we can build a prosperous, equitable, innovative, and sustainable India. I thank the Hon'ble Prime Minister and this august gathering for the opportunity to present the aspirations of the people of Tamil Nadu.

Thank you, Nandri – Vanakkam.

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